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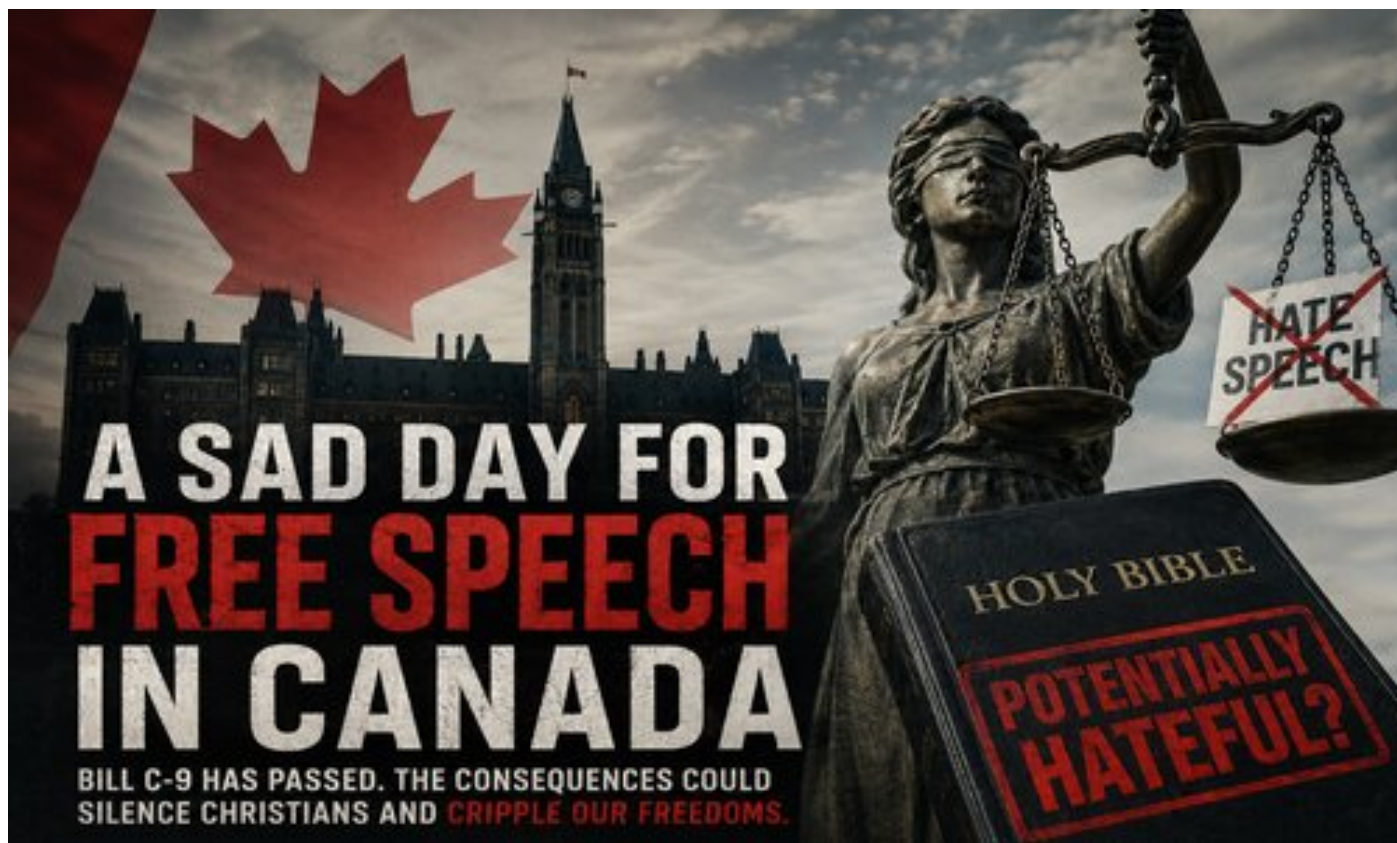
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ARTICLE

Bill C-9 Changes Everything For Canadian Christians



BY PNW STAFF JUNE 20, 2026

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There are laws that change tax rates. There are laws that adjust budgets. And then there are laws that quietly alter the relationship between citizens and the state.

Bill C-9 belongs in that second category.

Supporters describe the legislation as a necessary step to combat hatred and protect vulnerable groups. The bill expands Canada's hate-crime and hate-propaganda laws and introduces new measures designed to address hate-motivated conduct. On the surface, many Canadians may see little reason for concern.

But buried within the legislation is a change that has many Christians, civil liberties advocates, and free speech defenders sounding the alarm.

For decades, Canada's Criminal Code contained a defense that protected the good-faith expression of opinions on religious subjects and religious texts in certain hate-promotion cases. Bill C-9 removes that protection.

Supporters argue the change closes a loophole that could potentially be abused to justify genuine hatred. Critics see something very different. They warn that Parliament has removed an important safeguard that helped protect religious expression, leaving future courts and prosecutors with greater authority to determine where legitimate religious teaching ends and criminal hate promotion begins.

Whether those concerns ultimately prove justified remains to be seen.

But one thing is certain: a legal protection that existed yesterday no longer exists today.

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That should concern every Canadian who values freedom of conscience and freedom of speech.

After all, who gets to decide what constitutes hate?

Most Canadians would agree that direct threats, harassment, intimidation, and incitement to violence should not be protected. But modern hate speech laws rarely remain confined to those categories. Increasingly, they venture into the territory of ideas, beliefs, moral convictions, and religious teachings that others find offensive.

That is where many Christians see trouble ahead.

For generations, churches have openly preached what the Bible teaches about marriage, sexuality, gender, sin, repentance, and salvation. Those teachings have not changed.

Society has.

What many Canadians regarded as mainstream moral beliefs only a few decades ago are now viewed by some activists as discriminatory, exclusionary, or harmful. That raises a question that would have seemed almost unimaginable a generation ago:

Could biblical teaching someday become the subject of a criminal hate-promotion complaint?

Supporters of Bill C-9 insist such concerns are exaggerated. They point out that Canada still recognizes freedom of religion and freedom of expression.

Perhaps they are right.

But laws are not judged solely by how they are intended to be used today. They must also be judged by how they could be applied tomorrow.

The concern is not what happens next week.

The concern is what becomes possible next week.

What happens when a complaint is filed over a sermon discussing Romans 1?

What happens when a Christian school teaches the biblical definition of marriage?

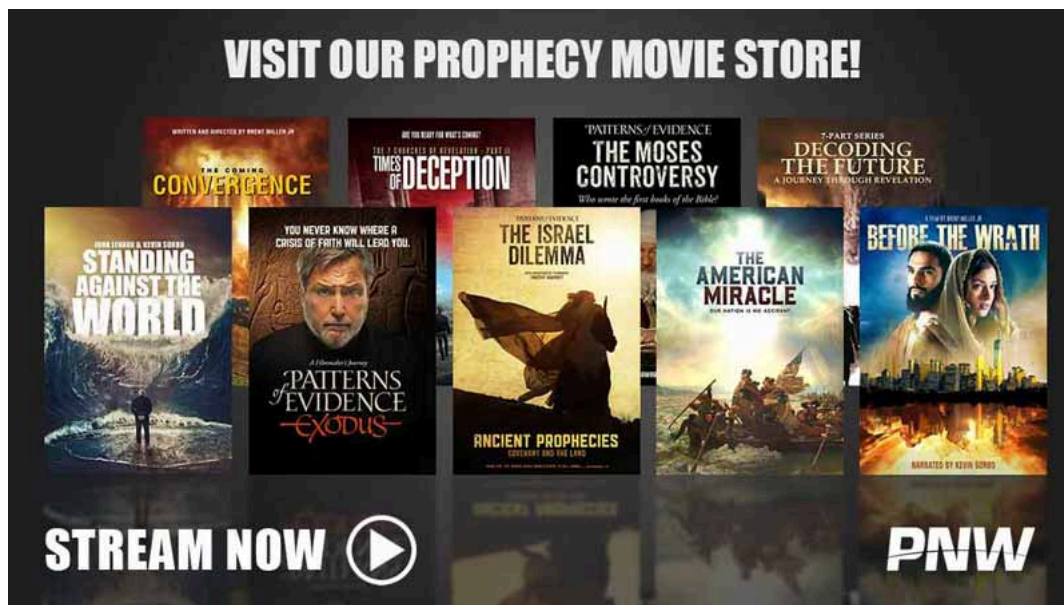
What happens when a pastor preaches that repentance involves turning away from sinful behavior?

What happens when biblical teachings on sexuality are viewed by activists as harmful or discriminatory?

Before Bill C-9, there was a specific statutory defense available in certain cases involving religious expression.

Now there is not.

That reality alone guarantees that future courts—not Parliament—will increasingly be asked to draw those lines.



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History offers a clear warning. The definition of "hate" rarely remains fixed. What one generation considers a legitimate moral belief, the next generation may consider offensive. What was once regarded as common sense can suddenly be branded harmful. The target keeps moving.

That is precisely why free speech protections were created in the first place—not to protect popular opinions, but to protect controversial ones.

No one needs legal protection to say what everyone already agrees with.

The true test of freedom is whether citizens can express views that others dislike.

Unfortunately, Canada has been moving steadily in the opposite direction for years.

Across the country, citizens have faced investigations for comments made online. Human rights tribunals have increasingly become battlegrounds for ideological disputes. Pastors, activists, educators, and ordinary Canadians have learned that expressing certain views can carry growing professional, financial, and legal risks.

Bill C-9 represents another step down that road.

For Christians, the concern is especially serious because the Gospel itself is inherently offensive to the spirit of the age.

Scripture teaches that all people are sinners.

Scripture calls people to repentance.

Scripture challenges human desires and behaviors.

Scripture claims that truth exists independent of popular opinion.

None of those ideas sit comfortably within a culture increasingly focused on subjective identity and personal autonomy.

The Christian message has always challenged prevailing cultural norms.

The prophets offended kings.

The apostles offended religious authorities.

Jesus Himself offended both political and religious leaders.

The Gospel was never designed to fit neatly within the cultural consensus of any generation.

That is why freedom of speech and freedom of religion are inseparable.

The moment government gains greater authority to determine which moral truths may be publicly expressed, religious liberty becomes vulnerable as well.

Perhaps the worst fears surrounding Bill C-9 will never materialize.

Canadians should certainly hope that is the case.

But hope is not a safeguard.

History suggests that powers granted to government rarely remain confined to their original purpose. Definitions evolve. Boundaries shift. New precedents emerge. Future governments often use powers in ways their predecessors never imagined.

And once precedent is established, recovering lost freedoms becomes far more difficult than defending them beforehand.

For that reason alone, Bill C-9 should concern far more than Christians. It should concern every Canadian who values the right to speak, debate, persuade, disagree, and proclaim what they believe to be true.

Because when governments gain greater authority over speech, the question is rarely whether that authority will be used.

The question is where the line will eventually be drawn.

And who will find themselves standing on the wrong side of it.

That is why many Canadians view the passage of Bill C-9 not as a victory for freedom, but as a warning.

A warning that Canada may be moving one step closer to a future where certain opinions remain protected—not because they are true, but because they are approved.

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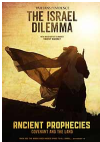
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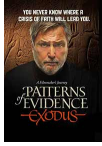
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